

Afternoon Discoveries

September 26, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Speculative, Hybrid, Experimental, Short & Flash Fiction

Some stories build another world from the ground up. Others only move one piece of ours slightly out of place. A body can be borrowed, a hotel can exist between destinations, a dead relative can refuse to remain dead. Memory can remember a television show that may never have existed, and a flower can look back.

Today's shelves are full of stories that use the impossible less as an escape from ordinary life than as a way of turning it around in the light. Some are compact enough to finish over a cup of coffee. Others ask for considerably more time. Nearly all of them leave something behind after the strange machinery stops moving.

All links were checked against the linked publication or magazine page on September 26, 2026.

Featured Discovery

My Fingers Formed Into Guns - Jenny M. Liu

There is a ruined world here, but Jenny M. Liu is less interested in explaining every piece of it than in asking what remains after people try to engineer their way out of violence.

Annie moves through ghost-ridden streets carrying grief, anger, memory, and the consequences of an invention that was supposed to offer an answer to war. Soldier bots, the dead, the Director who keeps calling, and a companion whose relationship with Annie is prickly yet intimate all occupy the same fractured landscape.

Technology and haunting sit beside each other without asking permission. The dead appear, bodies have been changed. Violence has become mechanical and personal at once. Even the distinction between weapon and wounded person begins to feel unreliable.

Read at [Strange Horizons](#)

The Discovery Desk

Maskwork Saltman Giftbox - Rich Larson

Rich Larson's compact story follows a worker who takes jobs wearing reconstructed faces and performing whatever emotional task the algorithm has assigned. Sometimes that means giving somebody another encounter with someone who is gone. Sometimes it means reenacting the most painful thing that person could possibly see.

The premise is speculative, but the economics around it are painfully recognizable. The narrator is doing maskwork only until something better comes along. The work is intimate, psychologically punishing, and governed by an algorithm, yet it remains work that needs to be completed before the next job arrives.

At just over a thousand words, Larson manages to fit grief, automation, gig labour, identity, cruelty, and the commodification of memory into a space smaller than many opening chapters.

[Read at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Beneath the flower's gaze - Kevin Rigathi

Kevin Rigathi structures this Omenana story through several encounters with an impossible place in Kwale, where unfamiliar

flowers grow around an old house and curiosity has consequences. The repetitions matter. Different people approach for different reasons, but desire keeps pulling them toward the same centre.

What initially feels like a haunted-estate story gradually reveals a stranger ecology involving the Mother of Flowers, transformation, human appetite, and a creature whose behaviour is frightening without fitting comfortably into simple ideas of malice.

The result has the shape of folklore while remaining grounded in very contemporary motivations: property, investigation, wealth, trespassing, curiosity, and the conviction that everything mysterious ought to belong to someone.

[Read at Omenana](#)

Jempo - Thomas Ha

Thomas Ha's story places Ruth, another competitor, inside a tournament whose rules become clear through use rather than exposition. Machines battle through something called dialectics. Their makers maintain, modify, and strategize around them. Ruth knows how this world works and how to exploit its angles. Aga approaches it differently.

Ha has said that the story began with Aga, a character slightly out of step with the people around her, but that Ruth became the viewpoint through which he could examine her. That choice gives *Jempo* an intriguing tension: the person narratively closest to us is not necessarily the person whose way of seeing the world matters most.

Competition gradually becomes a story about compromise, information, ambition, and what a victory is worth when getting it changes nothing that needed changing.

[Read at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

The Red Veil - Daniel Roop

There is a door.

Behind it is something that should not be here.

Daniel Roop begins with a veteran following a friend home after their service together and gradually discovering that his friend's family has another occupation entirely: keeping certain things from crossing into our world.

That premise could easily become straightforward monster hunting. Instead, Roop complicates it with documents, records, competing perspectives, and another thread involving an aspiring insurance salesman and an elderly woman in Tennessee.

The mundane and cosmic repeatedly collide. Insurance pitches sit beside occult training. Old family routines sit beside things that strain the boundaries of reality. Tomatoes can matter as much as rituals. Trauma acquired in war does not conveniently disappear because a larger supernatural threat has arrived.

At more than eight thousand words, this is the longest piece in the free portion today, but its hybrid construction keeps changing the angle from which the central horror is approached. Nightmare's editor Wendy N. Wagner describes it as a story about a family fighting the weird and the evil, with

bizarre taxidermy thrown into the mixture. That is accurate, but only part of what is going on behind the door.

[Read at Nightmare Magazine](#)

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Drawers of the Discovery Desk

Small Wonder - Meg Elison

Meg Elison takes the familiar experience of half-remembering old media and lets it become progressively less comfortable. Internet results almost provide answers, then destabilize them. Nostalgia starts opening doors Kathy may have had reasons to keep shut.

There is an especially effective tension between pop-cultural memory and personal memory here. Old television is disposable until it is not. A forgotten programme may be harmless debris from childhood, or it may be the shape a mind has given something much harder to hold directly.

Small Wonder is speculative fiction operating at the boundary where memory becomes unreliable enough to function like

another world.

[Read at The Rumpus](#)

Parts and Halves - Alia Ai-Ming Shahzad

In Alia Ai-Ming Shahzad's world, bodies participate directly in an economy of exchange. One person needs a toe, someone else has a finger they can afford to lose. People with sufficient money can replace what is broken, and those without it occupy a much more precarious position in the system.

That contradiction sits at the centre of the story. The speculative mechanism is vivid and strange, but Shahzad uses it to make labour, class, family obligation, bodily autonomy, and upward mobility brutally physical. A person's market value is no longer metaphorical when the market can price the pieces of their body. Exploitation travels through the family, but so does love, and eventually so does the possibility of refusing the arrangement altogether.

[Read at Apex Magazine](#)

In the Blue Hour - RJ Aurand

RJ Aurand's flash fiction begins with the mechanics of a revenant story and then quietly changes what kind of haunting it is. The narrator has inherited Emmeline's estate, along with a

dead relative she never particularly liked, and treats the returning body as a problem to be solved.

Old family resentments, exclusion, inheritance, prejudice, and memories that may have been accepted too easily begin to look different once Emmeline is sitting there, unable to explain herself and equally unable to disappear.

At 876 words, *In the Blue Hour* is a good demonstration of what flash can accomplish when it does not waste the impossible thing at its centre. Resurrection is not the revelation; it simply gives two people one last opportunity to sit together long enough for something else to become visible.

[Read at Apex Magazine](#)

Room 602 at the Hotel In-Between - Georgina Kamsika

Georgina Kamsika turns liminality into an actual building, filling it with travellers and the seductive possibility of living permanently between choices. Christie, whose life already consists of airports, crew bunks, rolling luggage, and relationships maintained through layovers, finds the place almost perfectly suited to them.

Kamsika's accompanying author material describes nostalgia as potentially predatory, and that idea helps unlock the story. Comfort is not always restoration. A place made entirely from thresholds can become another kind of prison if remaining unfinished begins to feel safer than moving.

[Read at Nightmare Magazine](#)

Seeds of the Storm - Bongiwe Maphosa

A strange woman has been appearing nearby. Thunder seems unusually responsive. An old amulet points toward the uThekwane, a lightning bird drawn from Nguni mythology and associated here with storms, ancestral presence, immense power, and transformation.

Bongiwe Maphosa builds the story around a young person discovering that what is happening to her is not simply an unexplained disturbance to be eliminated.

The editors of *Omenana* describe *Seeds of the Storm* as an uncanny coming-of-age story in which reaching a new stage is not an arrival but a journey toward a mantle that must be earned. Sbane's growing understanding requires more than discovering a hidden supernatural world. It requires deciding what relationship she will have with something that is frightening, powerful, and already part of her story.

[Read at Omenana](#)

Not Even a Fly - Phoenix Alexander

Phoenix Alexander builds an unsettling moral problem in this story. If someone experiences terrible desires but builds an entire life around ensuring they are never acted upon, what exactly should we make of the person who remains? Does restraint make him good? Does the existence of the thoughts make him dangerous? What happens when he encounters somebody whose relationship with violence is very different?

The speculative power also gives the story an unusual sensory range. Leaving a human body changes scale, time, perception, vulnerability, and even what consciousness feels like. The narrator's stone becomes less a magical object than an ethical refuge.

Nightmare's description calls him a pacifist with the heart of a serial killer and a mysterious superpower. The tension between those identities is exactly where the story becomes difficult to put down.

[Read at Nightmare Magazine](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

What Kind of Person Would a City Like Wickhills Produce?: A Conversation With Premee Mohamed - Martin Cahill and Premee Mohamed

In this conversation Premee Mohamed talks about *Wickhills*, her approach to building its magical city, and the work of constructing a spy story inside a place where the strange is woven into ordinary life. She discusses how the city grew from research, travel, and disconnected ideas, and how its surveillance, bureaucracy, and isolation shape the people living there. The result is an interesting look at worldbuilding as something that influences character rather than simply surrounding it.

[Read the conversation at Reactor](#)

Interview with Author Alia Ai-Ming Shahzad - Marissa van Uden

In this interview Shahzad talks with Marissa van Uden about the narrator's lost eye, exploitative work, the illusion of upward mobility, intergenerational love, and the long process of turning the original conceit into a finished story.

The narrator gains perception through loss. The story itself also became clearer through removal. Shahzad describes an earlier draft almost twice the finished length, full of images and themes that eventually had to be cut so the story's central movement could emerge.

The conversation also ranges into writing habits, community, artistic influences, Shahzad's Pacific Crest Trail experience, and how writing during that journey changed their willingness to share work publicly. *Parts and Halves* ultimately became Shahzad's first accepted short story.

For writers, it is a useful reminder that a strange premise does not arrive with its final architecture attached. Sometimes the work is figuring out what the story can survive without.

[Read the interview at Apex Magazine](#)

Xicanxfuturism: Codex 1
edited by Scott Russell Duncan
- Reviewed by Jacqueline Nyathi

What does a speculative tradition look like when imagining the future is itself part of preserving a people in it?

Jacqueline Nyathi's review of *Xicanxfuturism: Codex 1* looks at a collection that deliberately refuses to limit itself to conventional short fiction. The volume brings together fiction, nonfiction, poetry, visual art, political thought, cultural memory, and speculative imagining under the idea of Xicanxfuturism.

That mixture is part of why it belongs on today's experimental shelf.

Nyathi considers the codex in relation to Afrofuturism, Africanfuturism, Indigenous futurism, Chicanafuturism, questions of language and archives, environmental concerns, identity, migration, history, and the role speculative work can play in imagining futures for communities whose histories have often been distorted or erased.

The anthology's form appears to be part of its argument. A future does not have to arrive as a single clean narrative. It can be assembled from fragments, art, argument, memory, story, and people disagreeing about what comes next.

[Read the review at Strange Horizons](#)

Special Recommendations

Some stories have been sitting on the shelves for years waiting to be read.

The Bookmaking Habits of Select Species **- Ken Liu**

Ken Liu's 2012 story imagines several intelligent species and the radically different ways they preserve thought, experience, knowledge, and memory. The result reads almost like speculative anthropology. Rather than following a conventional protagonist through a plot, Liu moves between civilizations and their methods of making information endure. A book may be architecture. It may be biological. It may work through forms of memory or matter that make the human codex look provincial.

Underneath all of that invention is a recognizable anxiety: civilizations disappear, people die, and knowledge is always trying to outlive the mind that held it.

[Read at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Ponies **- Kij Johnson**

Kij Johnson takes the social ritual of fitting in and makes the cost literal. Barbara wants acceptance from the other girls. Barbara also has Sunny, a magical pony. Belonging requires making changes. The fantasy imagery is deliberately bright, sugary, and childlike.

At the centre is a brutal little mechanism familiar far beyond childhood; a group decides what a person must surrender to become acceptable, and the person being asked to surrender it understands perfectly well that compliance may not actually produce belonging.

For anyone who thinks flash fiction is merely a smaller container for a smaller idea, *Ponies* remains persuasive evidence to the contrary.

[Read at Reactor](#)

Welcome to Your Authentic Indian Experience™ - Rebecca Roanhorse

At Sedona Sweats, tourists can purchase an “authentic” Native experience through virtual reality. The problem is that authenticity, in this business, is largely determined by what customers already expect Native people to look and behave like. Rebecca Roanhorse turns that premise into speculative fiction about performance, identity, appropriation, economic pressure, and the strange violence involved when somebody else’s fantasy of who you are becomes more valuable than your actual self.

The second-person narration makes the experience particularly uncomfortable. The reader is not permitted the comfortable distance of watching Jesse perform from outside. The story repeatedly pushes its machinery of simulation, substitution, and identity closer until the question of who is playing whom becomes much harder to answer.

Published by Apex in 2017, the story later won both the Nebula and Hugo awards for Best Short Story. Nearly a decade later, its central speculative device feels less remote, while the human problem inside it has not aged at all.

[Read at Apex Magazine](#)

Some of these stories are enormous in what they try to build. Others barely need a few pages before the floor begins moving beneath them. I hope at least one gives you that particular pleasure speculative fiction can offer.

*Thank you for spending some of your day among the letters with us.
Take care!*